

Game Design Document

Iron Tide - Tactical Naval Combat

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1- Design History – Changelog

Version	What Changed?	Date	Who
1.0	First Draft	03-10-2025	Elshan
2.0	Major redesign — replaced the mission system and installation mechanics with direct tactical combat and range-based dice combat. Updated Goals, Gameplay, Rules, and Procedures sections.	16-10-2025	Elshan, Oskar
2.1	Adjusted the game to be split into 3 combat rounds divided by 2 shopping phases. Wrote notes on how the shopping segment plays out and specified the 3 round model.	22-10-2025	Oskar
2.2	Added extra paragraph under 5.1. Added table for all of our module cards / passives if needed. Some minor changes here and there based on the latest agreements.	26-10-2025	Sami
2.3	Filled out the module table with all module cards that we have and adjusted what information about them is given. Corrected the needed dice to also show D8.	28-10-2025	Oskar
2.3	Balanced and clarified module cards	28-10-2025	Elshan
2.4	Added the Epic and Death Card tier cards to the table. Removed the terrain rule for islands under 5.4 and	29-10-2025	Oskar

	rewrote part of the Setup phase under 5.5 to more fit the current state of the game. Added a list of components used in the game under 5.3.		
2.5	Restructured some of the descriptions of components under 5.3.	30-10-2025	Oskar
2.6	Added resource distribution with a table under 5.2	30-10-2025	Sami
2.6	Added details on target audience, platform, player characters and game world overview, under 3.1, 3.2, 6.2.1 and 8.1.	30-10-2025	Oskar
2.7	Developed/expanded further on: 3.1, 3.2, 3.3, 3.4, 3.5, 4, 5.3, 5.6, 5.7. Added Board Game Rules	31-10-2025	Elshan
2.7	Added to 5.7, added a flowchart of the game loop under 5.8, removed some chapters that would not fit the kind of game that this is and corrected some chapter numbers. Added chapter for the rules sheet. Quick check for errors with formatting or spelling.	31-10-2025	Oskar
2.8	Final edits	31-10-2025	Oskar
3.0	Added - Game Components visual. Fixed 5.2 table of modules error. Final Edits	02-11-2025	Elshan
3.0	Fixed naming inconsistency in 5.2 Table of modules. Added missing game component visuals. Moved title for Game Manual to be last in order and added number to Game Component Visual.	02-11-2025	Oskar

3.1	Added a segment about playtesting (7) and changed numbering to fit the change.	07-12-2025	Oskar
3.2	Added a new segment 5.9-5.9.2 including strategies, example playstyles and gameplay variety	09-12-2025	Sami
3.3	Added 5.9 and 5.10	09-12-2025	Elshan

2- Goals and Vision

Core Concept: This is a tactical, dice-driven naval combat board game where players command modular ships across a grid-based ocean map. Each turn combines movement, positioning, and combat decisions that rely on both strategic foresight and dice outcomes. The game's focus is on tactical maneuvering, range management, and the gradual destruction of a ship's core modules rather than traditional hit-point depletion.

Each ship is built from three key components — **engine, weapon, and armor** — each providing bonuses that directly influence gameplay mechanics. As combat progresses and modules are damaged, ships lose performance and capability, simulating a gritty, mechanical breakdown at sea. Once all modules are destroyed, the ship sinks and the player is eliminated.

The aim is to capture the feeling of **slow, deliberate naval warfare**, where positioning and timing matter as much as luck. Players must read the battlefield, predict enemy ranges, and use movement and terrain to gain the upper hand. Different weapon types encourage varied playstyles — close-range brawlers, long-range snipers, or balanced mid-range fighters — ensuring that every encounter feels distinct.

The design prioritizes **tactical depth with simple execution**: all players roll D6s for movement and combat, but the modifiers, distances, and range effects create layers of strategic nuance. Victory comes not only from rolling well, but from planning smartly — anticipating enemy actions and managing module durability to stay afloat.

3- Audience, Platform, and Marketing

3.1 Target audience

Iron Tide is suited for audiences 12+ as there are plenty of smaller calculations and it requires a decent understanding of strategic decisions to be played, it is also suited for adults of any age. It is not dependent on geographic location nor is the targeting of the game dependent on gender.

The game is intended for 3-4 players in a session. English will be the primary language for the game materials, but the design relies on symbols and numbers making it easier for non english speakers to understand the gameplay.

Players who enjoy classic naval battle games like battleships but crave a deeper game will find Iron Tide appealing. The social aspect of negotiating temporary truces or rivalries that occur during sessions are what makes Iron Tide a great social game.

3.2 Platform

Iron Tide is a physical tabletop board game and was chosen as such to allow for easier testing of features as well as allowing it to be developed without needing much knowledge in programming, which would be needed for developing it digitally. We chose the board game format to encourage face to face interactions which is important for the gameplay.

3.3 Top performers

Battleship: (Milton Bradley/Hasbro, first published in 1967). The classic grid based naval combat game for two players has sold over 100 million copies worldwide, Battleship is a much simpler game than Iron Tide, focusing on blind guessing rather than tactical movements.

Star Wars: X-Wing Miniatures Game (Fantasy Flight Games, 2012): A popular tactical combat game where players maneuver starfighters using templates and dice rolls for combat. At its peak X-Wing was one of the best selling tabletop games attracting a large community. Iron Tide shares some design features with X-Wing, such as modular upgrades for ships and the importance of maneuvering and range.

Pirates of the Spanish Main (WizKids, 2004): A constructible strategy game where players built small pirate ship models from cards and battled each other. It had a strong following for the time and

had multiple expansions in the mid 2000s. Its sales were big enough for it to get its own RPG adaptation. Iron Tide shares the pirate esque theme.

3.4 Feature comparison

The titles above represent some of the competition Iron Tide has. Each has elements that overlap for example, Battleships naval grid, X-Wings tactical movement and dice combat, and pirates theme of modular ships. None combine these elements in the way Iron Tide has done. We don't see Iron Tide as a pirate or battle ship game, what makes Iron Tide a great game is that it has that social aspect that the other games don't have.

3.5 Sales expectations

Iron Tide is right now a university project and not an established commercial product, sales projections are speculations at this point. Assuming a successful launch via crowdfunding we could project an approximation of around 500 units sold on the initial release, this includes early backers and pre orders from kickstarter. Marketing will be heavily dependent on word of mouth and online interactions within the board game communities.

4- Legal Analysis

Iron Tide faces minimal legal hurdles as it is an original work made by students. The main concerns will be securing the name, protecting the IP, and ensuring that all the assets used are legally obtained.

5- Gameplay

5.1 Overview

Each player controls a single ship represented by three modules: an **Engine**, a **Weapon**, and an **Armor**. The objective is to be the last ship afloat by tactically maneuvering, attacking, and surviving encounters with other players.

Players roll dice to move across the 18x18 grid tile board, position themselves within weapon range, and attack opponents. The interaction between range bonuses, terrain effects, and module bonuses forms the heart of the gameplay loop.

The game is divided into 3 rounds. After the first round is complete the player will get resources and the shop will open up for the player to buy or replace modules. All modules the player has acquired beforehand will be restored to full health. 1 module contains 10 healthpoints. Same thing applies for going into the last round. See shopping phase for further information.

The game is played on a **tiled ocean map**, where each tile is adjacent on four sides (no diagonal movement). Some tiles may contain **rocks** that block or weaken attacks and restrict a player's movement options.

The main loop of the game is split into three parts of battle divided by shop segments, where the players make use of the gold they gained based on how they performed during the previous battles.

5.2 Gameplay description

Turn Order:

At the start of the game, all players roll a six-sided die (D6) and add the bonus from their engine if they have one. The player who rolls the highest begins the game, and turns proceed clockwise.

On a Player's Turn:

1. Movement Roll:

The player rolls one D6 and adds their **Engine bonus**. The total determines how many tiles they can move. Movement is only allowed horizontally or vertically.

2. **Action Choice:**

After moving, the player chooses one of two options:

- o **Attack:** Target another player within range based on their weapon's distance.
- o **Extra Movement:** Roll another D6 (without the Engine bonus) for additional movement.

3. **Attack Resolution:**

- o The attacking player measures the straight or diagonal distance (like a queen in chess) to the target.
- o If the target is within the weapon's range, the attacker rolls the corresponding dice type (depending on weapon category).
- o Bonuses and penalties are then applied based on range modifiers, weapon bonuses, and the target's armor.
- o The target reduces their health accordingly.

4. **End of Turn:**

After combat or movement, the turn passes clockwise.

All resource rewards are granted after a round is completed, with the exception of First Blood and any player to player bribes/deals, which are resolved immediately.

Resource distribution:

Name	Type	Amount of gold	Round
First blood	Destroy the first module in the round.	5	Round 1, Round 2
Wanted Cards	Complete your bounty.	6, 12	Round 1, Round 2
Wanted Cards	Pass your bounty/mission to another player once you are defeated. If the other player completes it you both gain resources.	3, 6 gold each.	Round 1, Round 2
Placement	Last place, Third place, Second place, First place, Draw.	Last 10, Third 12, Second 10, First 20, Draw 15.	Round 1, Round 2
Bribes/deals	Bribe or make a deal with another player.	The amount decided upon. (if not paid immediately the player has the choice to not pay it later)	Round 1, Round 2

Shopping phase:

When combat ends either due to mutual agreement from remaining combatants or from only one player remaining on the board, the shopping phase begins. Two decks of cards are shuffled, one containing **Low power** modules and one containing **High power** ones. Five low power cards and five high power cards are placed on the table and the person who sank first in the round prior gets to start buying followed by the person to the left until every player is done.

When a card is bought it gets replaced by one from the deck to keep the shop stocked. A player can choose to sell an owned module for a low amount of gold which may assist in affording newer ones. Higher power modules are more expensive than the low power ones and the deck of high power modules also holds a few **Legendary** modules which cost even more but are a lot more powerful.

Once the shopping phase ends it is followed by the next out of the three battle segments.

Table of all Modules:

Module Type	Tier	Base Modifier	Dice Used	Passive Name	Passive Description
Long Range Weapon	1	+2	1xD6	-	-
Long Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Long Shot	You may attack from a range of 7 tiles without any bonus.
Long Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Mortar	You may shoot over rocks without any disadvantage.
Long Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Bishop	+2 Damage to diagonal shots. -1 Damage to straight shots.
Medium Ranged Weapon	1	+2	2xD4	-	-
Medium Range Weapon	1	+1	2xD4	Perfect Shot	If your attacking dice are the same, you may roll an additional dice.
Medium Range Weapon	1	+1	2xD4	One of Each	After attacking another player you may choose to pull

					the player towards you 1 tile or knock them back 1 tile.
Medium Range Weapon	1	+1	2xD4	Rook	+2 Damage to straight attacks. -1 Damage to diagonal attacks.
Medium Range Weapon	1	+1	2xD4	Healthy Collector	+1 Damage when attacking the highest health opponent on the board. (Each undamaged module counts as 10 hp).
Short Range Weapon	1	+2	1xD6	-	-
Short Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Boarding Party	When you attack while adjacent to another player, steal 1 gold from them.
Short Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Grappling Cannon	Before you attack, pull the other player 1 tile towards you.
Short Range Weapon	1	+2	1xD6	Strong Arm	When you attack you may knockback the player 1-2 tiles.
Short Range Weapon	1	+1	1xD6	Doubleshot	If you destroy an enemy's module you may attack another player, so long as they

					are within range.
Armor	1	+2	-	-	-
Armor	1	+1	-	Rookie	-2 Damage from straight attacks.
Armor	1	+1	-	Supplies	While at full health reduce damage from attacks by 2.
Armor	1	+1	-	Scrappy	At the start of your turn regain 1 hp.
Armor	1	+1	-	Look-out	If another player has a bonus to their damage from range, reduce the damage dealt by 1.
Engine	1	+2	1xD6	-	-
Engine	1	+1	1xD6	Momentum	When moving twice in one turn you may apply the bonus to both moves.
Engine	1	+1	1xD6	Gust of Wind	If another player is within 2 tiles, you may knock them back a tile.
Engine	1	+1	1xD6	Sneaky	When you are next to a rock you take -1 damage per rock.
Engine	1	+1	1xD6	Runaway	If another player is directly adjacent to you at the start of your turn, you may

					move twice and then attack.
Long Range Weapon	2	+3	1xD6	-	-
Long Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Bishop	+2 Damage for diagonal shots.
Long Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Piercing Shot	If more than one player is on the same diagonal or straight when attacking your damage is applied to both.
Long Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Lead Shell	When attacking another player you may choose to apply your damage as knockback instead of dealing damage.
Medium Range Weapon	2	+3	2xD4	-	-
Medium Range Weapon	2	+2	2xD4	Retribution	If another player destroys one of your modules, you may attack them once for free. (Range modifiers are not adhered to for retribution attacks).
Medium Range Weapon	2	+2	2xD4	Healthy Collector II	+2 Damage when attacking the highest health opponent on

					the board. (Each undamaged module counts as 10 hp).
Medium Range Weapon	2	+1	2xD4	Rook II	+3 Damage for straight attacks.
Medium Range Weapon	2	+2	2xD4	Perfect Shot	If your attacking dice are the same, you may roll an additional dice.
Short Range Weapon	2	+3	1xD6	-	-
Short Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Grappling Cannon II	Before you attack, pull the other player up to 2 tiles towards you.
Short Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Doubleshot	If you destroy an enemy module you may attack another player, so long as they are within range.
Short Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Boarding Party II	When you attack while adjacent to another player, regain 2 hp.
Short Range Weapon	2	+2	1xD6	Sea Horse	You may attack anyone within a 2 tile radius.
Armor	2	+3	-	-	-
Armor	2	+2	-	Bishop	-2 Damage for diagonal shots.

Armor	2	+1	-	Cheat Death	When you reach 1 hp you stay at 1 hp until the next attack.
Armor	2	+2	-	Scrapper	When you destroy an enemy module, regain 3 hp.
Armor	2	+2	-	Hunker Down	When an enemy attacks you may choose to take 2 damage and make them reroll.
Armor	2	+2	-	Dodge	If another player crits against you, (rolls the highest number on their dice) roll a D6, if it's odd the enemy will miss.
Engine	2	+3	1xD6	-	-
Engine	2	+1	1xD6	Scavanger	You may choose to forego your attack and instead roll a D4 and heal however many hp.
Engine	2	+2	1xD6	Evade	If another player crits against you, (rolls the highest number on their dice) roll a D6, if it's even the enemy will miss.

Engine	2	+2	1xD6	Ramming Speed	When you move adjacent to another player on your first move, they lose 1 hp.
Long Range Weapon	Legendary	+3	1xD8	Lucky	When you roll an odd number you may roll again, once per turn.
Long Range Weapon	Legendary	+1	1xD8	Precision	If you destroy another player's module you may choose the module freely.
Medium Range Weapon	Legendary	+3	2xD6	Coordination	You may split your attack between two players dealing 1 D6 + your bonus to each.
Short Range Weapon	Legendary	+3	2xD4	Overkill	When you deplete an enemy's health bar, the enemy will take half of the remaining damage (rounding down) and apply it to the next health bar.
Armor	Legendary	+5	-	King of the Sea	You have strong armor but your movement is fixed to 2 per turn regardless of your engine bonus or dice roll. (Engine

					abilities still apply).
Engine	Legendary	-1	2xD4	Surprise Mother Trucker	Pay 1 gold to switch places with another player.
Engine	Legendary	+3	2xD4	Wolf Pack	You may choose to attack before you move.
Engine	Legendary	+1	D6	Queen of the Sea	You may move diagonally without any extra cost.
Long Range Weapon	Epic	+1	D6	Marauder	+3 Damage while you have 5 hp or less.
Medium Range Weapon	Epic	+1	2xD4	Death of Duty	+4 Damage against players you have not yet attacked this round.
Short Range Weapon	Epic	+2	D6	Hard Shell	When you knockback another player into a rock they take 1xD4 of damage, if you knockback a player into another player they both take 1xD4 of damage.
Armor	Epic	+1	-	Hull of Honor	+3 Armor against players you have not attacked this round.
Engine	Epic	+2	D6	Tactical Retreat	When an enemy attacks

					and damages you, you may move one tile in any direction. (If this module is destroyed you may move one tile before it is destroyed).
Engine	Epic	+1	D6	Sea Begger	+1 Damage when attacking.
Long Range	Death Card	0	D6	Avenger	+3 Damage against the winner or winners of the last round.
Medium Range	Death Card	0	3xD4	Merry Gambler	When attacking another player, roll an additional D4. (Totalling 3 dice).
Short Range	Death Card	0	D6	Chain Shot	+1 Damage for every undamaged module your opponent has.
Armor	Death Card	0	-	Underdog	+1 Armor for each undamaged module your opponent has.
Armor	Death Card	0	-	Potempkin	+1 Armor for each opponent left in the game.
Engine	Death Card	0	D6	Geurilla	+1 Movement for every opponent left in the game.

5.3 Controls

Since this is a tabletop game, the “controls” are physical dice rolls, movement on a grid map, and health/module trackers.

Each player should have:

- A **ship board** with three module slots (Engine, Weapon, Armor).
- A **health indicator**.
- Dice: D8, D6 and D4 depending on weapon type and engine.
- Range reference chart for distance bonuses/penalties on their weapon card.

Rolling a die will determine the distance of movement or attack outcomes. The randomness that is introduced by the dice rolls is a core part of the control mechanism, the players’ influence is decided by the modules they get later in the game making chance less impactful.

Movement is executed by physically picking up one's ship token and placing it at the appropriate number of tiles away from the starting point where the player rolled the dice.

Tracking health and module status is done through a health tracker that slides so as to make it easier for the players to track their health while playing. When a module is destroyed that specific module is then rotated 90 degrees to indicate that the module is destroyed for the other players.

Cards are drawn, revealed and discarded by hand. Wanted cards are kept secret in each player's hands and only revealed when the turn is over. Gold tokens/coins are exchanged for purchases of modules or rerolls of modules.

5.4 Rules

Materials and Components

The game contains:

- A tiled board where the players move their tiles.
- 4 player pieces that will show the position of each player on the board.
- 4 “ship boards” where each player can place their module cards and keep track of their health bar.
- 4 health bar indicators used to move on the health bar and show how much health a player has.
- Coin pieces with the values 1, 5 and 10 gold used as currency.
- Dice, at least one four sided, six sided and eight sided for the players to use in most actions of the game.
- Module and bounty cards (in more detail below).

The game makes use of multiple types of cards categorized into different decks to act as different modules or missions for the players:

- **Tier 1 module cards:** These cards are the starters for players and can be obtained by 5 gold each in the shopping segment and sold for 2 gold.
- **Tier 2 module cards:** These are more powerful than the tier 1 modules and can be purchased in shops with 10 gold and sold for 5.
- **Legendary module cards:** These modules tend to be more powerful than any tier 2 but might also change the way you play the game in some ways. They share a deck with the tier 2 modules, making them rather rare. Their cost at shops is 20 gold and they sell for 5.

- **Death module cards:** These modules are meant to prevent them from falling too far behind. The modules are rather weak in comparison to any other card as an incentive to want to replace them. They are granted to a player who was sunk during a round and do not sell for any amount of gold, but can be discarded at a shop.
- **Wanted cards:** These cards are few but important. They describe a **bounty** and contain a player number and offer a reward if the player holding the card manages to land the last hit on the specified player. If a player gets themselves on the card, they instead have to be the last player standing to be granted the reward. A player is to keep this card secret from the other players until the end of the round when any completed bounties will be rewarded.
- **Epic module cards:** When a player completes the bounty on a Wanted card they get to choose between an amount of gold as specified on the bounty, or an Epic module as a reward. These fit somewhere in between tier 1 and tier 2 cards in terms of power and can be sold for 5 gold in a shop.

Weapon Categories and Mechanics:

Type	Dice Rolled	Range	Distance Modifiers	Special Effect
Short Range	1×D6	4 tiles	1t = +2 / 2t = 0 / 3t = -1 / 4t = -2	<i>Knockback:</i> Push target 1 tile directly away if possible (optional)
Mid Range	2×D4	4 tiles	No bonuses or penalties	None
Long Range	1×D6	6 tiles	3-4t = 0 / 5t = +1 / 6t = +2	<i>Piercing Fire:</i> Can shoot through rocks (-2 damage per rock)

Attack Resolution Order:

1. Roll weapon dice.
2. Apply range modifiers (based on distance).
3. Add weapon module bonus.
4. Subtract target's armor value.
5. Apply resulting damage to the target's health bar.

Module Damage System

When a player's **health bar** reaches 0 the player who destroyed it rolls a D4.

- 1 = Weapon,
- 2 = Armor,
- 3 = Engine,
- 4 = The player gets to choose which remaining module to destroy.

If the player rolls a number that equals a module that is already destroyed the player gets to choose.

Once one of their three modules (Engine, Weapon, Armor) becomes **damaged** and loses its bonus effect:

- A damaged **Engine** no longer grants extra movement.
- A damaged **Weapon** no longer adds its damage bonus.
- A damaged **Armor** no longer reduces incoming damage.

Each module effectively represents one “life.”

When all three are destroyed, the ship **sinks** and the player is **eliminated** from the game.

Terrain Rules

- **Rocks:** Block line of sight unless using a long-range weapon (–2 damage per rock passed through).
- **Open Water:** Normal movement and line of sight.

5.5 Game Procedures

Setup Phase

- Each player places their ship on a predetermined starting tile. That being the tiles marked with an ‘X’.
- All weapon cards in the tier 1 card deck are taken out and shuffled before each player is given one card (Is only done the first round).
- The ‘Wanted’ cards are shuffled and are distributed to the players. These are to be kept secret until the end of the round.
- Determine player order by rolling D6 (highest goes first).
- Each player sets their module bonuses and health to full.

Turn Sequence

- **Movement Roll:** Roll D6 + Engine bonus → move that many tiles (orthogonally).
- **Action Phase:** Choose to attack or roll again for extra movement.
- **Attack Resolution:** Follow combat steps and apply damage.
- **Module Check:** If a ship reaches 0 HP, mark a module as destroyed.
- **End Turn:** Pass play clockwise.

Elimination

- Once all modules are destroyed, the ship sinks and that player is out. The player’s piece on the board is given to the player who eliminated them as a way to keep track of who defeated who. All pieces are returned once the round is over.

Victory Condition

- The last remaining ship in round 3 wins the game. During rounds 1 and 2, two remaining players can choose to end the round in a draw.

5.6 Scoring/winning conditions

A point based system is not used in Iron Tide. There is no cumulative score tallied during or after the game, instead victory is determined by the **last ship standing**. The game effectively ends in a win for one player and the rest loses.

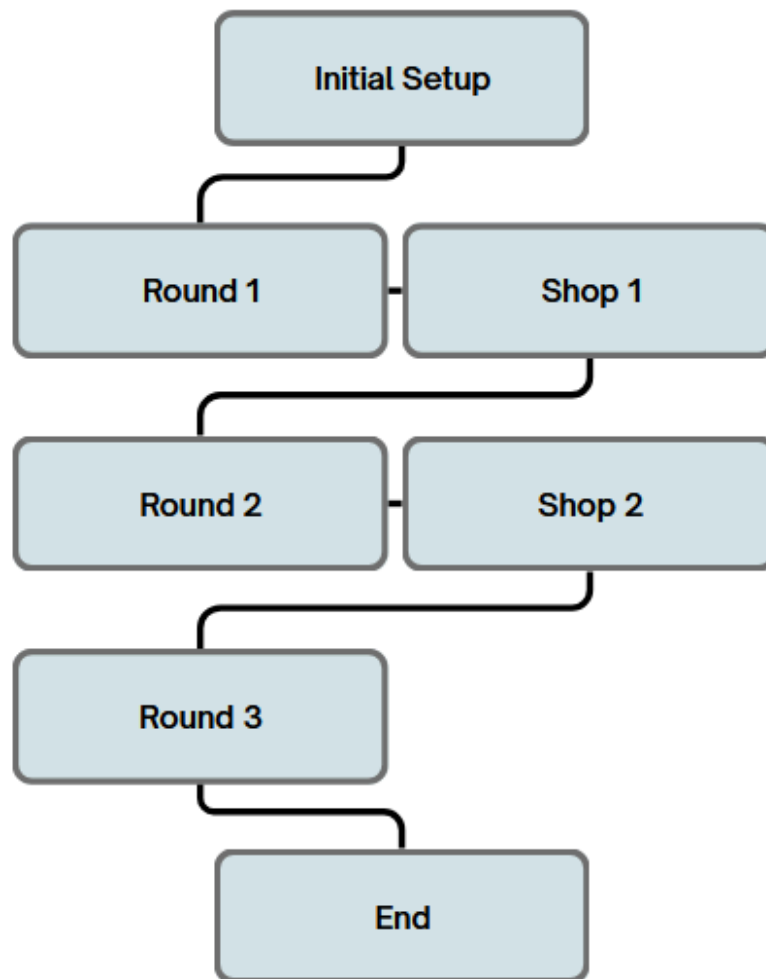
This design leaves room for alternative play modes that could be introduced in the future with a possibility for expansions or other variants of the original game. For example Timed battles or mission cards that will grant points, but this is in the foreseeable future.

5.7 Modes and other features

Some module cards in Iron Tide may adjust some of the basic rules of the game, such as being allowed to pull an enemy player a tile closer to the bearer of the module before attacking, or a module allowing a player to move diagonally with no extra movement cost.

5.8 Flowchart

This flowchart shows the game loops through players turns within rounds, and loops through three rounds within the full game. It also highlights the shopping phases as distinct breaks from combat.



5.9 Strategies and different playstyles

Iron Tide supports multiple strategies to ensure victory. While dice rolls, the shop draws module cards, the ship system and resources allow players to adopt different playstyles and strategies. The game encourages adaptability by giving players freedom to change all modules and encouraging alliances and betrayals for ultimate payout. That is possible since the win condition is set for the last round.

Examples on how you can create your playstyle based on the modules:

- **The Aggressor** (Short range Weapon & high mobility)
 - Focuses on closing the distance quickly to utilize the high damage short range weapons provide.
 - A tactic fit for this type is trapping players against corners or by rocks to force engagements where the opponents can't retreat easily.
 - A weakness is the vulnerability to longrange opponents if you are not able to close the gap in an open field. Or taking heavy damage from other players if the initial attack doesn't go your way.
- **The Sniper** (Long range & positioning)
 - Utilizes the long range weapon to deal damage from a safe distance and being able to shoot through rocks.
 - A tactic is to stick to open water or utilize the rocks to hide or create distance.
 - A weakness is low damage output in close quarters and long range weapons rely heavily on keeping distance.
- **The All Around** (Mid range weapon)
 - More flexible weapon where you can utilize different buffs or bonuses to create a diverse playstyle. The All Around is more consistent then the other weapons and doesn't rely as heavily on great pairs for the modules.
 - A tactic for the mid range weapon is to either play it more like the Aggressor or the Sniper role.
 - A weakness is that it doesn't get the same bonuses as either of the other weapons when played in the optimal way.

5.9.2 General Strategies

Economic snowballing: Since the ultimate victory is set in round 3 players may intentionally play aggressively in round 1 to secure First Blood and or trying to complete the bounty. If that player is able to complete all the resource objectives there is a chance to buy great modules and snowball from there into round 2 and further into round 3. A **warning** from the developers is that if you are too overpowered the others may create alliances against you.

Politics: The game's social aspect is another strategic tool. Players can bribe others, create or for alliances to eliminate stronger threats or just for the benefit of both. If you are in a weaker position during round 1-2 a viable option is to negotiate draws to gain more gold. Since everything is temporary you can choose to exit or betray your allies when you see fit. Since this is a 3 round game, tread carefully and choose your alliances wisely.

Terrain: Rocks are more than obstacles, they are defensive tools. Players use the -2 damage per rock rule to shield themselves from attacks while waiting for their turn or to lure other players closer to you.

5.9.3 Gameplay Variety

The varied gameplay comes from the random elements in the dice and from the randomization in the Shopping Phase. These elements make it impossible for a player to stick to one strategy every game or even in the same game. An example of this could be that the shop only drops different engines and armors when your strategy was to pair the existing modules with a long range weapon. Or if you are simply unlucky with the dice rolls you may not be in the position or having the impact you were planning. Same goes for previously mentioned political strategies. How well can you really count on your alliances and bribes? Play and find out!

5.10 Map development & design intentions

The core battlefield in Iron Tide is a grid-based ocean map. Early prototypes experimented with both hexagonal and square grids, but after testing the team chose a square grid because it is easier to draw, easier to visualise and was more familiar to players. Each tile connects on its four orthogonal sides to avoid ambiguity about adjacency and to make planning movement straightforward. The design objective for the map was to provide tactical variety without overwhelming players. To achieve this, we iterated through different map sizes and shapes and settled on a medium-sized square arena that can comfortably accommodate 3–4 ships with room to manoeuvre.

Rock placement and terrain strategy

- Rocks are the only static terrain on the board. They are more than decorative obstacles; they act as defensive tools that reduce incoming damage by 2 per rock when positioned between the attacker and the target. Our design intentions when placing rocks were:
- Create cover and choke points. Rocks break up long lines of sight so that long-range weapons do not always dominate. By placing clusters of rocks near the centre and corners, players are encouraged to make strategic use of cover or to lure opponents into traps.
- Encourage movement and flanking. Open water lanes are left between rock clusters so that aggressive playstyles can still close the distance. Diagonal movement is deliberately disallowed, but diagonal shooting is permitted; this tension means rocks can force players to reposition for a clear shot.
- Maintain fairness. The map is designed to be symmetrical so that no player gains an inherent positional advantage at the start. During set-up each player starts on a tile marked with an 'X' closest to them. Rocks are arranged so that every starting position has comparable access to cover and open lanes.
- Support special abilities. Several modules interact with rocks, such as the Mortar (shoot over rocks) and the Sneaky engine (take –1 damage per rock). Rock placement was tuned so that these abilities feel meaningful: there are enough rocks on the board to make these passives attractive, but not so many that the game becomes a stalemate.

To aid future map design, we created a template showing recommended rock positions. The template divides the board into a 7×7 grid and assigns 8–10 rock tiles in mirrored clusters. This number of obstacles proved to be a good balance between open water and cover during playtests. Designers can adjust the density slightly to make matches faster or slower, but symmetry and accessibility should be maintained.

5.11 Turn and phase flowcharts

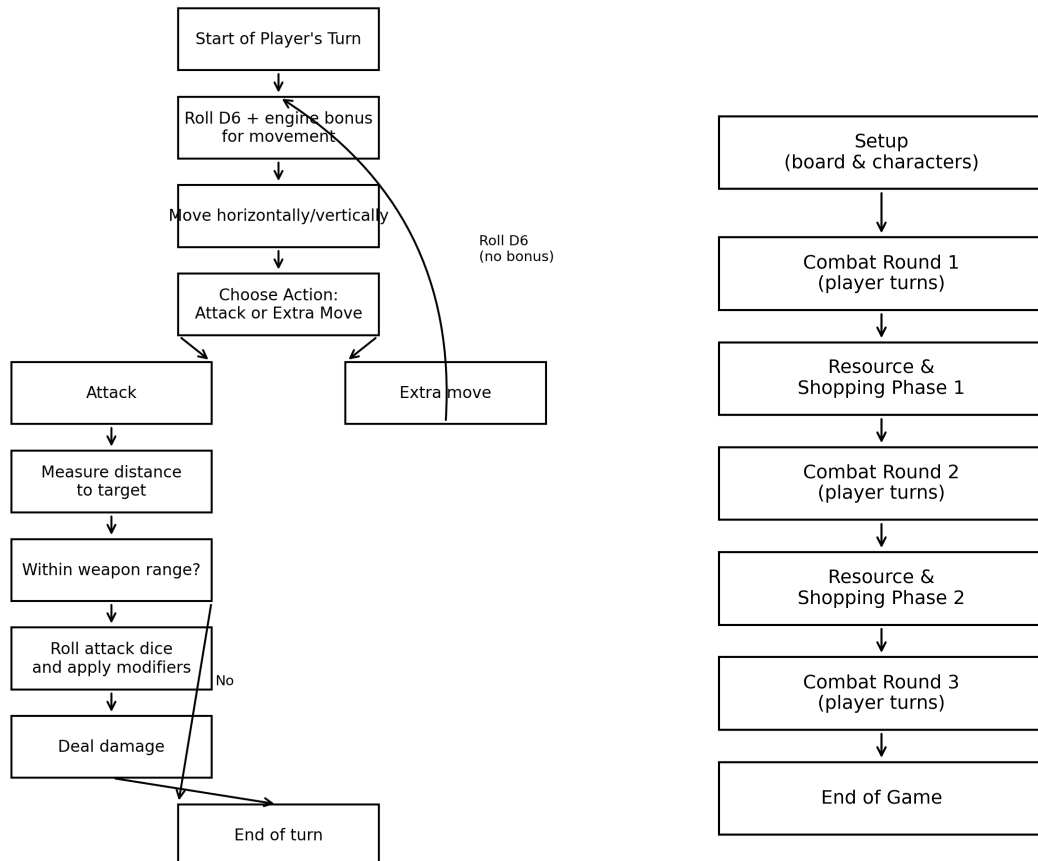
Complex rule descriptions can be hard to parse in prose, so we created flowcharts to visualise the order of operations on a player's turn and within a full game. These diagrams summarise the rules already described in Section 5.2.

Player turn sequence

Each turn follows the same sequence of actions. The flowchart below shows how a player moves, chooses an action and resolves attacks. If the player chooses Extra move instead of Attack, they roll a D6 without adding their engine bonus, move again and then end their turn. An attack only resolves if the target is within range.

Game phase structure

The overall game loop consists of three combat rounds separated by resource distribution and shopping phases. After the board is set up, players fight through Combat Round 1; once only one captain remains (or a draw is agreed) resources are awarded and the Shopping Phase begins. Players repeat this loop twice more before the game ends. The following flowchart shows the phase progression:



6- Game Characters

6.1 Character design

Players do not control traditional characters but instead **customizable ships** made of three core components. These represent their capabilities and identity in the game:

- **Engine:** Defines speed and maneuverability.
- **Weapon:** Determines dice type, range, and damage behavior.
- **Armor:** Reduces incoming damage and represents the ship's durability.

As modules are destroyed, the ship's functionality degrades, a reflection of battle damage rather than hit points alone.

6.2 Types

All characters in the game are player characters and they start out on equal footing with a slight variation based on what kind of weapon each player is randomly given at the beginning. Once the game begins the winner is determined by strategic prowess, with some uncertainty from random dice rolls as well as what cards randomly appear as available in the shop.

7- Playtesting

7.1 Summary

The game went through a few iterations of the main gameplay loop. The first of which had a much larger scope compared to the final product. The main difference being having a larger board for the players to move around on outside of being engaged in combat. After a few early tests where only the combat had been in focus it became clear that the game could function very well without the larger board, with a larger focus on just combat.

7.2 Larger iterations

Each playtest which was done had different focuses based on what information was needed at a current time. Some tests were focused on trying to balance certain numbers while others could be adding or removing a certain feature to determine how the game would play with or without it. This segment will mainly focus on those larger tests and mostly those where the change stuck for a longer time.

7.2.1 The first tests

The very first tests were focused on finding out how to structure the combat in the game, they started very simple with very few choices available to the player which provided a freedom to build onto what already worked. It became obvious that combat would not be very engaging if the only action was to attack, which led to the addition of a smaller board where players could move during combat, as well as figuring out some values for the three different ranges. The first map for combat was very small with a hexagonal grid which later changed to a square grid from being easier to draw and having been more tested.

7.2.2 Refining combat

After a few tests of the battlemat where two players were put against each other and each player was allowed to move and then attack, the addition of a choice for the second action was made. Meaning that a player would roll to move and then got to choose if they wanted to roll for attack OR roll to move another time. This led to more control for the players' actions and led to more strategy behind actions depending on what type of weapon a player had.

7.2.3 The turning point

When two player combat had been tested for some time a test where four combatants played started. These showed a large difference in what weapon was stronger and required even more consideration with every move compared to when a player only had to account for one opponent. It became clear that combat could be very enjoyable and after realising the time needed to complete it the decision was made to cut the less developed part of the game that was outside of combat, freeing the weight of

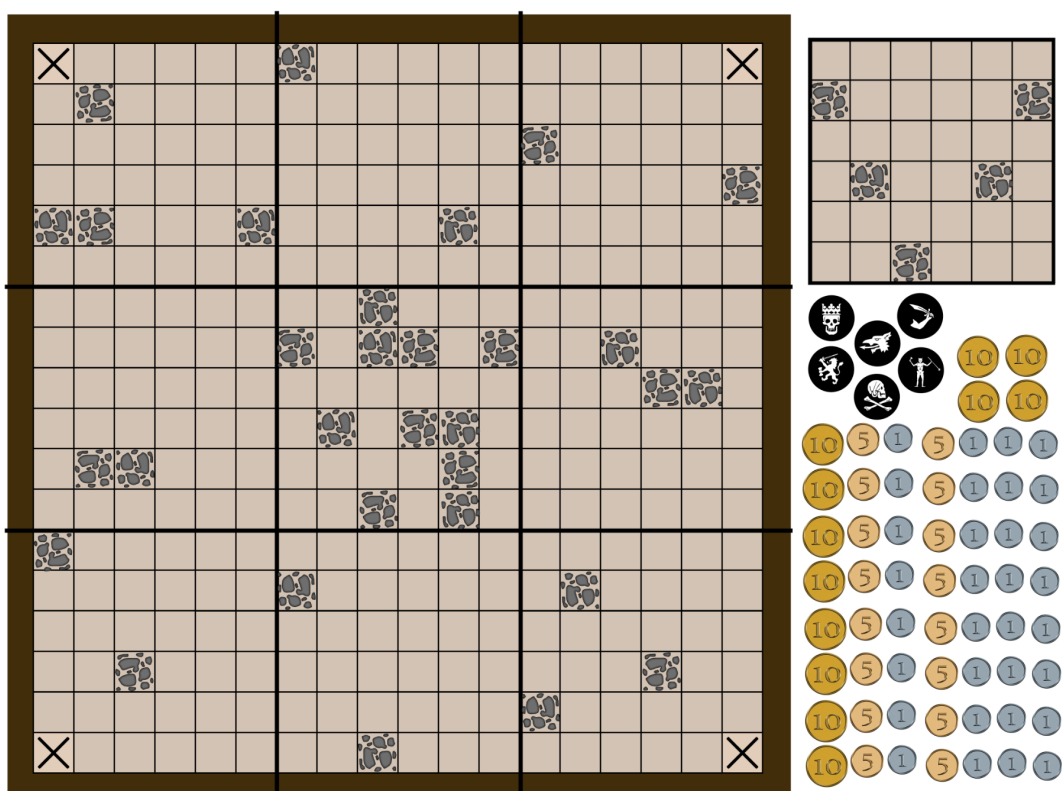
accounting for a decision's impact on that part of the game and allowing future development to focus on improving the parts which had been found entertaining.

Since the game would only consist of the combat part a version where multiple rounds was theorised and then tested and later the addition of the different abilities from different modules which finally led to the game resembling the Iron Tide we now know.

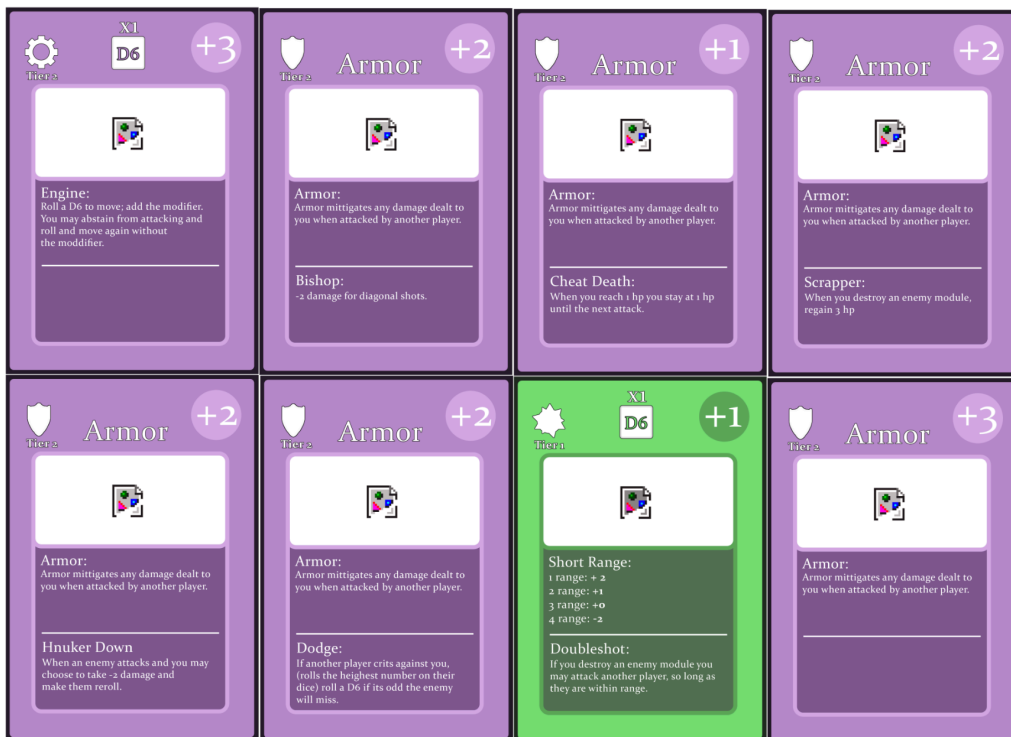
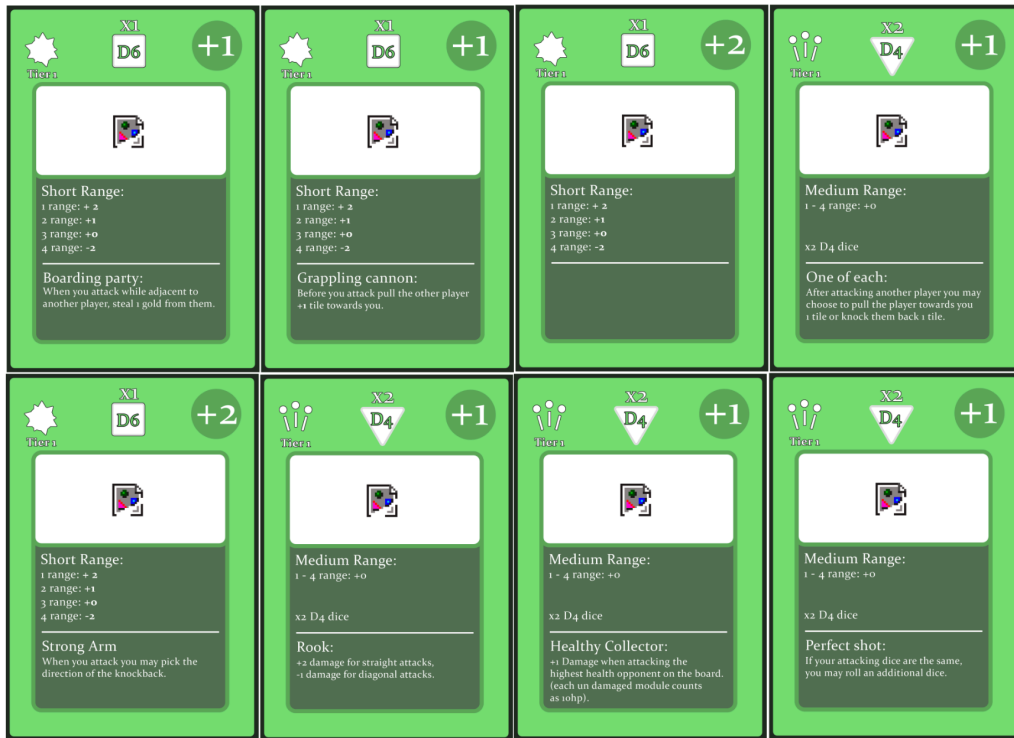
The very last playtests mostly focused on smaller changes in values and are therefore not worth going into much detail on.

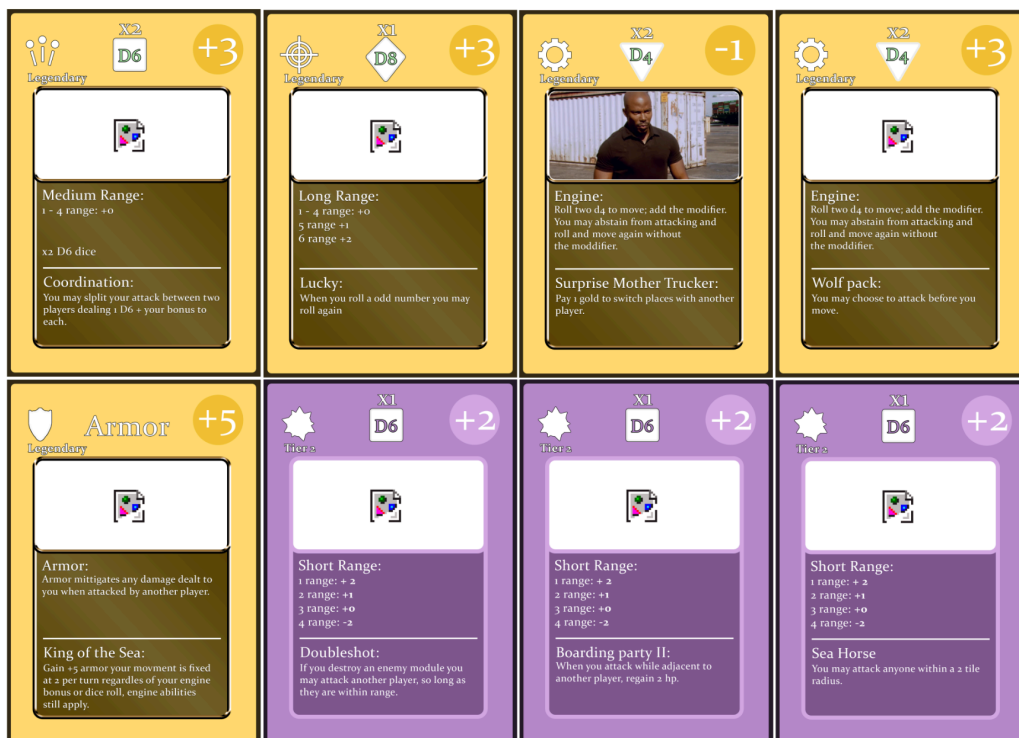
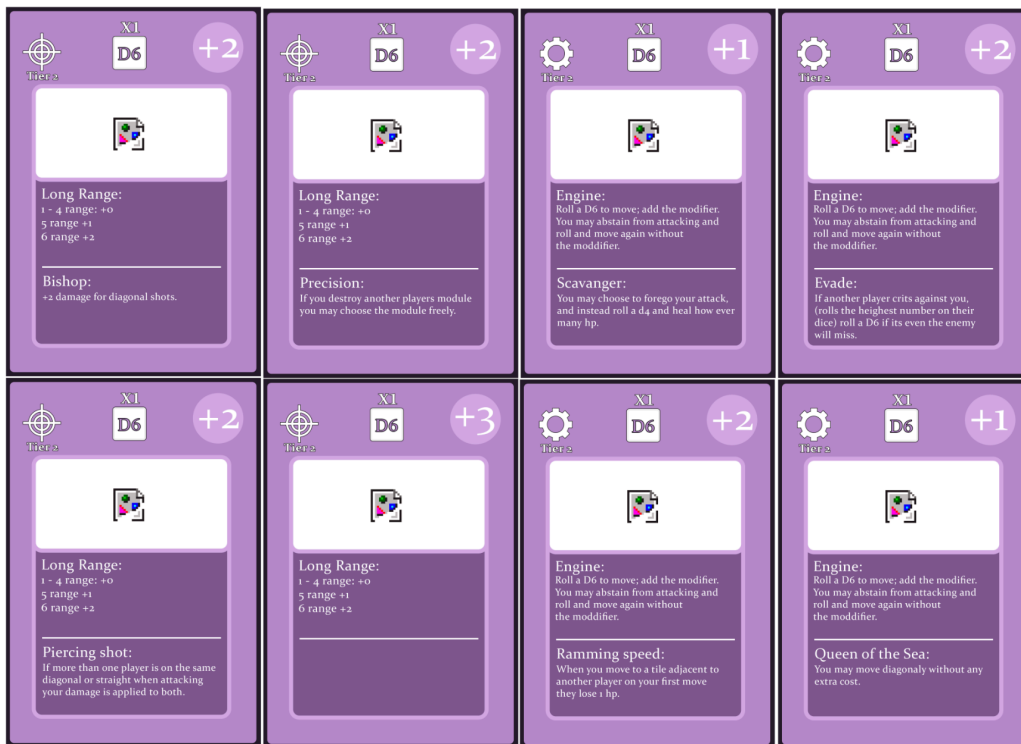
8- Game Components - Visual

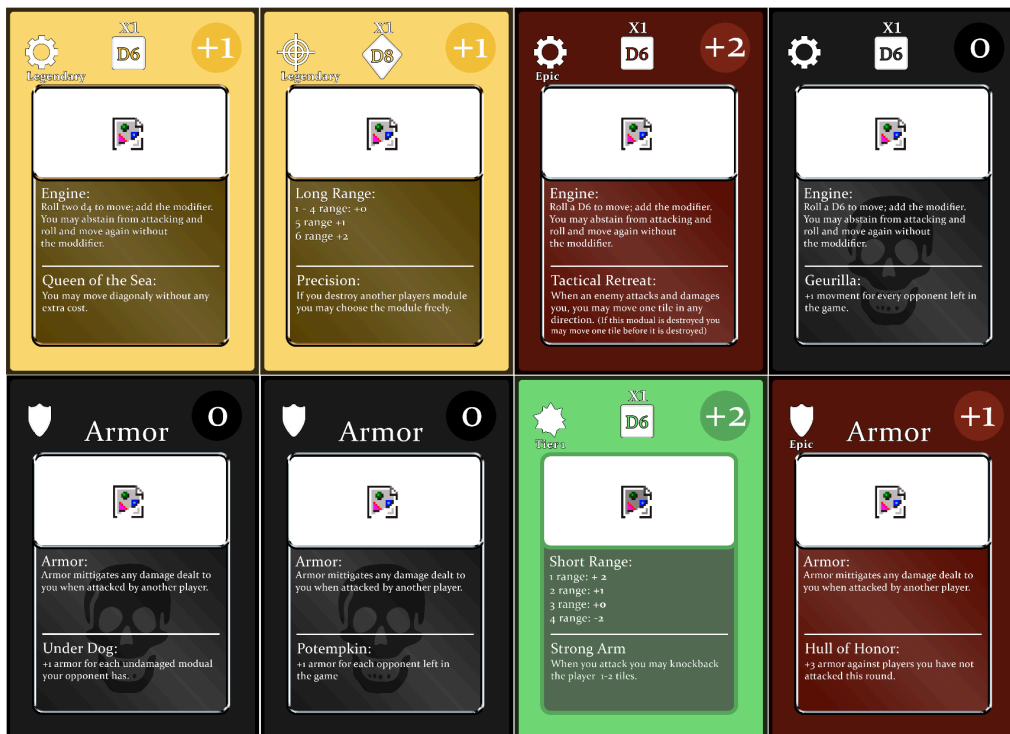
All visual assets shown in this section represent the current prototype stage of Iron Tide. Some elements such as module card designs may be updated, redesigned or scrapped prior to final production.

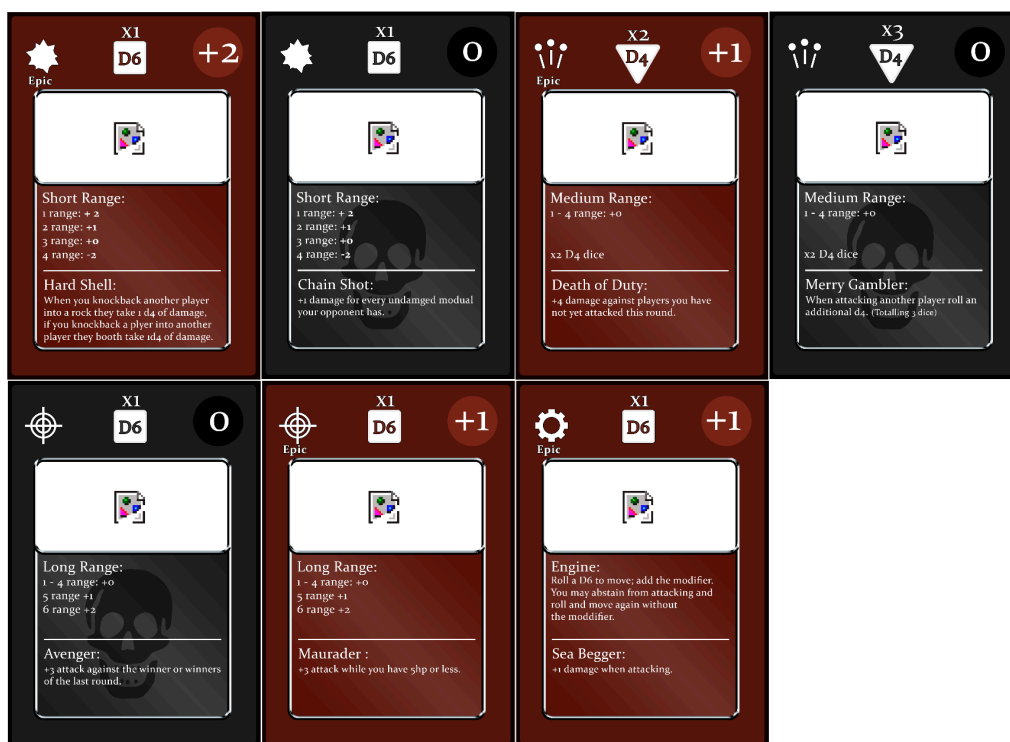












9- Game Manual

Viewed on the final pages of the document. The manual is saved in the state in which it was printed and may follow a different formatting than the rest of the document.

How to play Iron Tide

Overview:

This is a game about strategy, collaboration and betrayal. 3-4 players take the roles of captains at sea as they try to defeat the other players and stay as the last captain left. To succeed the players will need to upgrade the modules of their ship, as well as make use of their wits to outsmart opponents and find the best in any situation.

Time:

The game takes approximately 90-120 minutes to finish.

Components:

- A tiled board where the players move their tiles.
- 4 player pieces that will show the position of each player on the board.
- 4 “ship boards” where each player can place their module cards and keep track of their health bar.
- 4 health bar indicators used to move on the health bar and show how much health a player has. These are a larger version of the play pieces.
- Coin pieces with the values 1, 5 and 10 gold used as currency.
- Dice, at least one four sided, six sided and eight sided for the players to use in most actions of the game.
- Module and bounty cards (in more detail below).

Cards types:

- **Tier 1 module cards:** These cards are the starters for players and can be obtained by 5 gold each in the shopping segment and sold for 2 gold.
- **Tier 2 module cards:** These are more powerful than the tier 1 modules and can be purchased in shops with 10 gold and sold for 5.
- **Legendary module cards:** These modules tend to be more powerful than any tier 2 but might also change the way you play the game in some ways. They share a deck with the tier 2 modules, making them rather rare. Their cost at shops is 20 gold and they sell for 5.
- **Death module cards:** These modules are meant to prevent them from falling too far behind. The modules are rather weak in comparison to any other card as an incentive to want to replace them. They are granted to a player who was sunk during a round and do not sell for any amount of gold, but can be discarded at a shop. These are the only cards that do not themselves tell what card they are but can be recognized by their black color and skull in the background.
- **Wanted cards:** (Also referred to as bounty cards) These cards are few but important. They describe a bounty and contain a player number and offer a reward if the player holding the card manages to land the last hit on the specified player. If a player gets themselves on the card, they instead have to be the last player standing to be granted the reward. A player is to keep this card secret from the other players until the end of the round when any completed bounties will be rewarded.
- **Epic module cards:** When a player completes the bounty on a Wanted card they get to choose between an amount of gold as specified on the bounty, or an Epic module as a reward. These fit somewhere in between tier 1 and tier 2 cards in terms of power and can be sold for 5 gold in a shop.

Playing the game:

Setup:

1. Before the first round of the game the board should be placed with the map facing up and preferably so that all players can reach most of the board.
2. Each player should choose a play piece and be given a *ship board* as well as a *health indicator*.
3. The players place their play pieces on the tile marked with an 'X' which is closest to them, and move their *health indicator* to the number 10 on the *health bar* on their *ship board*.
4. Remove all weapon cards from the deck with *tier 1 modules*, then shuffle the weapon cards and give 1 to each player. Then return the other weapon cards to the deck.
5. Make sure to remove any bounty card that has no player counterpart from the *Wanted card* deck.
6. Shuffle all module card decks separately.
7. When playing you can try to create an alliance with another player to gain an advantage on the board, either by bartering gold or agreeing on a mutual threat. Remember that your allies might have their own plans and might betray you when they feel that the time is right.

The play loop:

1. **Each player is given a bounty card** which they keep secret until the end of the round. If it is the third round, bounty cards are not distributed.
2. **Initiative roll** - All players roll a D6 (six sided die) and add their engine bonus if they have one. The player who gets the highest number plays the first turn.
3. **Spending a turn**
 - 3.1. **Roll for movement** - Look at your *engine* card to determine what dice to roll and add the modifier number at the top left of the card, if you have no engine roll a D6. You may now move as many steps or less as long as they are not diagonal.
 - 3.2. **Action choice** - Choose to either roll movement another time (now without the modifier number on the card) OR roll to attack.
 - 3.3. **If you choose to attack** you need to make sure that you are within range of another player by counting the tiles in a straight or diagonal tile to them and comparing the distance to the range specified on the weapon card. When attacking, you will roll the dice specified on the card, add the modifier in the top right and any modifier based on the range as stated in the middle of the weapon card and then deal the sum as damage to the opponent. Also take note of any *passive bonus* read at the bottom of the card. An attack should be counted as Dice + Modifier + Range bonus + Passive effect.
 - 3.4. **A player hit by an attack** will move their health indicator down by the amount of damage taken minus their armor value (determined by the modifier number on an armor card. If the player has no card the value is 0). If it reaches the 'X' on the bar, continue to step 'e', otherwise the turn is over.
 - 3.5. **When a player reaches 0 hit points** one of their modules is damaged. Unless it was the last module, the attacker rolls a D4 (four sided die) to determine what module is damaged, a 4 or a number corresponding to an empty or already damaged module allows the attacker to pick what module to damage. Otherwise the modules are counted as 1-Weapon, 2-Armor and 3-Engine. The module which is damaged will have its card turned to the side and will no longer grant its modifier value or passive bonus until the next round, the dice specified is still used. The first player to cause

another player to lose a module in each round is rewarded 5 gold as a *first blood* bonus. If the player has no undamaged modules left they are sunk and out of the round, they will give their play piece to the attacker. If you are sunk you may give your bounty card to one of the players still in the game and later gain some of the reward if they manage to complete it.

4. **When two players are left** they can decide to either split the victory and both be given 15 gold each OR to continue until only one of them is left, in which case the victor would be awarded 20 gold and the loser 10 gold. The first and second player out are given 10 gold. The current round ends.
5. **If the current round was the third round** of battle there may only be one ship left, after which the game ends and the one lone captain is granted victory! Although if it was not the third round, continue to the next step.
6. **After a round** the players reveal their bounties and are rewarded if they had managed to complete the task described on it during the round, if they themselves did not manage to complete their bounty and had given it to another player who did both will be rewarded half the gold described on the card. A player who completed their own bounty can choose between a random card from the *Epic module* deck or the amount of gold specified on the bounty card. Players who were sunk are granted a card from the *Death module* deck.
7. **The shopping segment begins.** 5 tier one cards and 3 cards from the tier 2 deck are placed face up on the table. The player who was sunk first is first to have their turn at the shop, followed clockwise. Players can now purchase tier 1 modules for 5 gold, tier 2 modules for 10 gold and legendary tier modules for 20 gold. They may also discard any module they want, and are given 2 gold for a tier 1 or 5 gold for a tier 2, Legendary or Epic card, Death module cards can be discarded but do not grant any gold for doing so. A player may also choose to reroll the cards in the shop, to reroll the shop they pay either 2 gold to replace all of the tier 1 modules with new ones from the deck or 5 gold for the tier 2 and Legendary cards.
8. **Once all players are done in the shop** reshuffle the module cards and repeat from step 1 until all 3 battle segments have been played.